

The Cutting EDGE

Change is crucial for them and they come in all forms, from one-man armies to science revolutionaries, as institution builders and innovators. Redefining, restructuring and modernisation are the words that are their bookends. As Deepak Nayyar, economics professor from Jawaharlal Nehru University said, "Academics don't work with stock options. It's usually the rave reviews, the papers published or the ideas that catch on." That's what drives Sujatha Ramadorai whose work involves long lonely hours thinking about

elliptical curves and the non-communicative Iwasawa theory at her table. That's also what drives Sivaprakasam Sivakumar, a lecturer at DIET, who took it upon himself to charge the community into improving teaching in the 95 schools of Lagudi, often on his cycle, with only a bottle of water and his lunch for company. It's also what makes stars of innovative teachers like Rajeev Gowda at IIM, Bangalore, who uses Youtube downloads as part of his curriculum and the avant-garde Anant Pai whose *Tinkle* comics disseminate stories on Alexander the Great as easily as his *Amar Chitra Kathas* acquainted an entire generation with India's myths and legends.

For some educators, change begins in the classroom. Whether it's Delhi's Amrit Srinivasan, who tries to make sociology relevant to her technology-driven, science-oriented students at IIT Delhi or Aligarh Muslim University's Shireen Moosvi who brings to life dusty and frumpy

history, as she regales her students with tales of her hero, Akbar. Then there is AGK. Menon who turned a subject like architecture into something more "people-friendly" beyond bare bricks and mortar. For others, change begins outside the classroom, in the powerful corridors of policy. Like NCERT's Krishna Kumar who revitalised textbooks, encouraging knowledge-hungry students to ask questions, abandon mugging and make learning a hands-on experience. Or Centre for Science Education and Communication's Amitabh Mukherjee who revitalised science education and CNR Rao who has tried to take the subject out of lab into joyful classrooms and policy-making sessions with equal elan.

For all of them, there is only one goal. Securing the future of all their children. For it is only when equity and expansion exist that excellence follows. And it is only when the students of today become thought leaders of tomorrow will they have achieved their dream. ■

DEEPAK NAYYAR 63
PROFESSOR, Jawaharlal
Nehru University, Delhi

CLASS ACT

He has been a Rhodes scholar, an IAS officer, and chief economic adviser to three governments. But the job he is best regarded for is that of vice-chancellor of Delhi University between 2000 and 2005. "The classroom is my natural home," says Deepak Nayyar, who spent five years at St. Stephen's College between 1962 and 1967. From revamping the B.A. Pass course, where two-thirds of those who studied did not graduate, to restoring the majesty of the Viceregal Lodge; from making 500 faculty appointments to creating 1,000 more seats in the woefully crowded

RAVI S SAHANI

"She shows a connection between technology and society and its relevance to the student's life and thinking process." Vibha Arora,

Assistant Professor, IIT Delhi

Education M.A. from Delhi School of Economics and Ph.D from Cambridge University.

Last seen in Tel Aviv University, Israel, where she was the visiting chair in humanities and social sciences.

Different league Recently wrote the preface to Girish Karnad's *The Wedding Album* which involved self-introspection, very different from her academic writing.